would not have been systematic or linear. There would have been random wanderings, retracements and dead ends. Just as there were groups coming into the subcontinent, there were groups going out. Indeed, geneticists feel that India may have been the source of a number of important genetic lineages that are now found worldwide. Natural calamities, hunger, tribal wars and, most importantly, disease would have decided who survived and who did not. It is important to remember that a tiny difference in the constellation of circumstances in the Stone Age could show up as a dramatic difference in the genetic make-up of today's population.

There are plenty of remains of these early humans in Stone Age sites scattered across India. Bhimbetka in central India is one of the most extensive sites in the world although it was only discovered in the 1950s. It is now a UNESCO World Heritage site. The hilly terrain is littered with hundreds of caves and rock shelters that appear to have been inhabited almost continuously for over 30,000 years.

The country's climate and wildlife would have gone through a lot of change over this long period. For instance, the finding of beads and ornaments made from ostrich-egg shells show that the bird was once common in India. It is possible that the Stone Age fashion industry pushed it into extinction by targeting the eggs. Bhimbetka has rock paintings of animals and hunters from the Stone Age as well as of warriors on horseback from a later time (perhaps the Bronze Age). The paintings provide intriguing glimpses of the ancient origins of Indian civilization. As the BBC's Michael Wood puts it, 'Looking at the dancing deity at Bhimbetka with his bangles and trident, one can't help but recall the image of the dancing Shiva'. [18]

The last full-blown Ice Age started around 24,000 years ago, reached its peak around 18,000–20,000 years ago and then warmed up. From 14,000 years ago, the ice sheets were melting rapidly, the sea-levels were rising around the world and weather patterns were changing. The Persian Gulf began to fill up 12,500 years ago. [19] Around 7500–8000 years ago, the